

The River Dragon's Long Sleep

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

The Silver River is running low. All summer the rains have not come, and the terraced rice fields are growing thirsty. The grown-ups in the village look up at the dry blue sky and shake their heads.

Far up the mountain sleeps the Gentle River Dragon. When he stirs, the rains come. But he has slept far, far too long this time, and the river keeps sinking.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper calls you to her side. "You two have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she says. "Will you climb over the mountain and wake him, gently, before the harvest fails?"

She gives you three gifts: a little bronze bell, a ball of red thread, and a sweet rice cake. Then she smiles. "Up there we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Imagination, of Courage, or of Kindness?

Stop 1 The Guardian Gate

You climb the steep path and come to the Red Torii Gate. On each side sits a big stone lion-dog, still as rock. As you step close, they blink and stretch.

"None may pass," they rumble, "until you answer our riddle." They look fierce, but their eyes are kind. They like a good thinking face, and a brave guess is welcome.



What could you do? Could you listen closely and puzzle it out together? You could ask Kon the Fox for a hint. A thoughtful guess is allowed too. What do you try?

When you answer, the Guardian Lion-Dogs nod and lean back. "Well thought," they say. The gate swings open, and the path leads on.

Stop 2 The Moonlit Bridge

Night is falling now. Ahead, an old wooden bridge arches over the river, silver in the moonlight. It looks lovely, but it sways and creaks when you hurry.

You can feel it. This bridge only holds firm for those who cross it slowly and calmly, together, with a steady heart.



How will you cross? Could you go gently, hand in hand, taking a deep breath? Could you tie the red thread so you stay together? What is your plan?

When you cross slowly and calmly, side by side, the bridge holds firm under your feet. You step off the far end, safe, into the misty dark.

Stop 3 The Sleeping Dragon

At last you reach the wide, misty river. And there he is: the great River Dragon, curled along the water, vast as a hill, breathing slow. He has slept for so long that mist has gathered on his back.

This is not a fight. You could never wake such a giant by shouting, and you would not want to frighten him. He is gentle, and a little bit lonely.



What kind, calm thing could you do? You have a little bell that rings soft and clear. You could ring it and sing him a quiet, friendly song. What do you try?

When you ring the little bell and sing softly, the great dragon's sleepy eyes open. "Someone came," he murmurs, surprised and glad. "Someone came to wake me kindly."

The Rains Return

The River Dragon uncurls and rises, slow and grand, into the night sky. He winds above you like a long blue ribbon, and where he passes, soft rain begins to fall.

The Silver River brims and shines. Down in the valley, the thirsty rice fields drink deep and turn green again. The dragon is not lonely now, for he has friends.

High above, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami breaks through the clouds and smiles down on you. You did it together. You were brave, you were kind, and most of all, you were full of ideas. Well done, heroes.

The River Dragon's Long Sleep: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, with a long climb, a swaying bridge by moonlight, and a great sleeping dragon, but imagination and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Lantern Village.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a small bell or anything that makes a soft sound, a ball of string for the red thread, and a small cake or token for the rice cake. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these mountains, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Kon the Fox slips from the bamboo and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your calm again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts down the mountain, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Guardian Lion-Dogs nod kindly from afar. All is well.
5	A lucky cherry petal lands in your hand: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The soft ring of a temple bell sounds far off, and everyone feels calm and brave.

How it ends

The Gentle River Dragon at the misty river is the great "obstacle", but he is no villain at all. He is not angry, and he is not wicked; he is simply a kind old creature who has slept far too long and grown a little lonely. The tale is won not by force or by shouting, which would only frighten him, but by waking him gently and kindly, with the soft little bell and a calm, friendly song. Let that gentleness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The River Dragon's Long Sleep: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Guardian Gate (Normal)

The challenge. The two stone Guardian Lion-Dogs at the Red Torii Gate will not open the way until the players answer their riddle. They look fierce, but they are fair and patient, and they enjoy a good thinking face.

The riddle. Read it aloud: "I fall without ever being dropped. I drum on every roof, yet I have no hands. The thirsty fields all call my name. What am I?" The answer is **the rain** (the very thing the valley is waiting for).

Intended solution. This is a thinking challenge of Imagination and a little patience. Let the children talk it through together. The Guardian Lion-Dogs accept the right answer, and because they are fair and kind, they also accept a brave, thoughtful guess.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the lion-dogs offer a clue ("The whole valley is waiting for me, and the dragon's waking brings me"), or Kon the Fox whispers the answer from the bamboo nearby. A guess made bravely still opens the gate.

Stop 2: The Moonlit Bridge (Normal)

The challenge. The arched wooden bridge over the river sways and creaks. It holds firm only for those who cross slowly and calmly, together. The players must get safely across.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Courage moment. The thoughtful move is to cross **gently and together**: slow, steady steps, side by side, breathing calm rather than rushing in a fright. Tying the **red thread** between them so they stay linked, or counting out a slow, even rhythm as they walk, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are uneasy, let them take a deep breath and try again with no penalty, or have Kon the Fox call out a calming rhythm to walk to. Crossing with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Sleeping Dragon (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. The great River Dragon lies curled in the misty river, vast and mighty. The players may feel this is a battle, or that they must shout him awake. It is neither.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. The dragon is gentle and a little lonely, and a loud noise would only startle him. The kind, brave move is to wake him **softly**: ring the **little bell**, whose clear, gentle sound wakes a friend without a fright, and sing him a quiet, calm song. Speaking to him gently, or offering the **rice cake** when he wakes, deepens the friendship. When the children are gentle, the dragon opens his sleepy eyes and is glad someone came.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by force, have the dragon stir and murmur in his sleep, "Please, not so loud," so the gentle path is clear. The moment the players make any soft, kind sound at all, the bell or a hummed tune, the great dragon wakes warmly and is glad of their company.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the dragon wakes and rises, the soft rains return, the Silver River brims, the thirsty rice fields drink and turn green, and **Amaterasu the Sun-Kami** smiles down through the clouds. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins

here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.